▶ GOA

ON HOUSIE IN THE HOUSE

mutates into big-bucks betting, Goa cracks down. But the state may have scored a cultural self-goal



15.15 lakh. Winning numbers are often manipulated to ensure no one hits the jackpot. "Eventually, the organisers are the real winners," says the official, adding they pay neither income tax nor GST.

The business flies almost entirely under the radar. "They take loudspeaker permissions for cultural or musical events and hold Housie games instead," says the official. Early April, South Goa collector Egna Cleetus held a meeting to address this camouflaged surge in gambling. and put a stop on such 'soft' permissions. Violations attract action under the Goa Public Gambling Act, 1976. The crackdown has the full backing of chief minister Pramod Sawant.

Capt. Viriato Fernandes (retd), Congress MP from South Goa, fondly recalls the game of his childhood: tickets cost just 50 paise or a rupee and prizes were a modest Rs 10. He admits the present version is a mutant, but objects to selective enforcement, asking why the government does not act against casinos.

The ban has dealt a harsh blow to another vital part of Goan tradition: its 200-odd football clubs. "They organise Housie events at half-time, with tickets of Rs 50-100, and prize money of Rs 2,000-5,000," says Goa Football Association (GFA) president Caitano Fernandes. "These are crowd-pullers and clubs collect around Rs 3 lakh. This funds player fees, training, equipment, refreshments." The ban may force the smaller clubs to shut down or sit out tournaments. The GFA has appealed to the CM to withdraw the ban; while welcoming the crackdown on mega events, it seeks a conditional exemption. But a senior official says that can come only after the gambling menace is controlled.

"Housie has been a fixture in Goa since my childhood," says ex-MLA and activist Radharao Gracias, calling the ban a "completely thoughtless act". He acknowledges the game has been sullied by high stakes, but prefers regulation. "Instead, an entire tradition has been annihilated," he says, noting the wording of the ban notification would seem to cover "even lotteries, particularly in vogue during the Ganesh festival."

Takeaways

- **A cherished part of Goan life originally, which funded sporting events and festivals, Housie had of late mutated into high-stakes mass gambling**
- **The ban will affect 200-odd football clubs sustained by Housie proceeds**

WRONG NUMBER

Some welcome the ban. "It's not an attack on culture but a necessary intervention," says Peter F. Borges, assistant professor, Goa University, who once chaired the state's commission for child rights. "It had turned into mass gambling, with children present and no oversight. It's no longer about feasts and fundraising, it's about normalising risk-based behaviour under the garb of tradition. If we allow it to grow, we risk another matka-style menace." That form of betting has long seeped into Goa from its original home, Mumbai, and flourishes despite crackdowns. In Housie, Borges sees a kindred evil "that quietly seeps into our villages, our families and our children's minds".

Vijai Sardesai, Goa Forward Party MLA and ex-deputy CM, has another take. He alleges the ruling BJP's men still hold Housie events, giving "political patronage for illegal business." No ban seems likely on politics. ■